



Digital Article / Leadership

The Skills and Habits Aspiring CEOs Need to Build

Three experts on the qualities they find essential for navigating tough decisions. *by Vasundhara Sawhney*

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Illustration by Anthony Zinonos

It's no secret that today's business environment is volatile and unpredictable. From the Covid-19 pandemic to shape-shifting tariffs to the rise of gen AI, CEOs have a fresh set of challenges that the standard management playbook is ill-equipped to address.

As a result, many are heading for the exit. According to one survey of U.S. companies, nearly 2,000 CEOs announced their departures in 2024—the highest total on record.

At the same time, executive recruiters report that fewer people are interested in, or ready to, replace these exiting CEOs. This raises a number of questions: Are we at an inflection point in what future CEOs need to be successful? Is enough being done to equip up-and-coming CEOs to navigate these evolving dynamics? How can companies ensure future leaders are prepared to make tough decisions in chaotic times, and lead diverse, tech-first, and global workforces?

To answer these questions, we reached out to three experts:

- **Ginni Rometty**, former chairman, president, and CEO of IBM, serves on multiple boards and co-chairs OneTen.
- **Nitin Nohria** is the George F. Baker Jr. and Distinguished Service University Professor and former dean of Harvard Business School (HBS). He is the co-founder of HBS's New CEO Workshop.
- **Gary Burnison** is the CEO of Korn Ferry.

We specifically asked: What skills and behaviors should aspiring CEOs prioritize on building now to thrive in an increasingly complex world? And how can organizations support them in building these skills?

Here are their answers, edited for clarity.

Ginni Rometty: Prioritize Behaviors—Not Just Hard Skills

The rise of AI, geopolitical fragmentation, and evolving expectations around inclusion are reshaping leadership. Aspiring CEOs should prioritize behaviors—not just “hard” skills—to navigate this landscape of constant change. There are three key areas you should focus on.

Be an Olympic learner.

When I stepped into the CEO role at IBM, we were facing a rapidly shifting technology landscape—and a business model that needed to evolve. I approached that moment the way an Olympic athlete approaches their training—constantly iterating, stretching, and seeking input. I didn't need to have all the answers; I needed to ask the right questions and create a culture where others felt safe to do the same.

We instituted mandatory learning—40 hours for all employees—not as a simple requirement, but to make learning part of how the company worked and as a catalyst for a culture of growth. I personally taught the first hour of our monthly sessions for four years. This wasn't just symbolic; it signaled that in an era of technological disruption, continuous learning isn't optional but essential at every level of the organization.

That mindset is one I encourage every aspiring leader to embrace. It's especially critical as AI and automation change the nature of work and decision-making. Organizations must cultivate curiosity and create space for reflection, co-creation, and experimentation.

Steward good tech.

As the influence of AI and emerging technologies grows, future CEOs will need to do more than adopt innovation—they must steward it responsibly. This means making decisions rooted in long-term values, not driven by achieving short-term metrics.

One pivotal moment came when, at IBM, we decided to formally articulate our AI principles—especially around transparency and data responsibility. It wasn't driven by regulation, but by trust. We chose not to use client data to train our models, and we committed to being able to clearly explain how AI was being deployed. These weren't just policies; they were leadership choices made to earn and protect trust.

Future leaders will be judged by how they balance innovation with responsibility and to enable that, organizations must embed ethics and stakeholder thinking into the core of leadership development. When creating tools of unprecedented power, the question they ask shouldn't be "Can we?" but "Should we? And how?"

Build resilience through relationships and attitude.

Don't treat relationships as transactional. Invest in people with authenticity, long before you need them.

During moments of crisis—like responding to a global event or facing difficult public scrutiny—it wasn't just my preparation or mindset that carried me through. It was the team, and broad circle of people, around me. People I had built trust with over years.

The right relationships offer perspective, helping us gauge what truly matters or see things from a broader angle. During IBM's transformation, I relied on a diverse network of relationships—from my husband Mark, whose humor and steadiness kept me balanced, to colleagues who would share hard truths when I needed to hear them.

Attitude is how we choose to deal with challenges. When facing criticism about IBM's strategy, I reminded myself that I knew the truth about our progress. Instead of absorbing the negativity, I focused on celebrating the quiet milestones—the ones that never made the headlines but signaled real progress. I also learned to compartmentalize—dealing with one crisis at a time, putting it in a mental box, and moving forward.

Resilience allowed me to forge ahead through setbacks, conflict, crises, and critics. Organizations can help leaders build this by actively fostering networks, encouraging mentorship, and elevating emotional

awareness as essential to success—for individuals, teams, and the company.

The next generation of CEOs will succeed not by credentials alone, but by how they keep learning, lead with integrity, and respond to complexity. We need to prepare the next generation to lead with *good power*: leadership rooted in purpose, progress, and in service of others. The most effective CEOs will be those who understand that how we work and lead is as important as what we achieve.

Nitin Nohria: Master the Art of Proportionality

A skill that aspiring leaders must master right now is the ability to size up problems with a sense of proportion. In a world where leaders are inundated with a daily torrent of issues—some urgent, some trivial, some existential—the first and most essential act of leadership is triage. You must be able to distinguish the signal from the noise, set the right priorities, and focus energy where it truly matters.

Consider something like tariffs. Leaders don't need a perfect forecast of how trade policy will evolve, but they need to size up its trajectory. What's the likely range of outcomes? Where will the dust settle? Making such judgments—calibrated, not knee-jerk—is what allows a leader to steer a company through uncertainty.

One of the most valuable questions you can ask when sizing up a problem is: (How much can I delay reacting in order to gather more information?) In statistics, the Bayesian approach offers a useful guide: Start with an informed prior, update it as evidence accumulates, and revise your beliefs accordingly. Leaders must become better Bayesians—curious, circumspect, and constantly updating their understanding of a situation as new data emerges.

Of course, there are moments when delay isn't an option. A fire needs to be extinguished, not analyzed. But the hallmark of good judgment is knowing the difference—when to wait, when to act, when to double down. That's the real art of proportion, and it's becoming a make-or-break leadership skill.

This is not just about geopolitics—though we are clearly in a turbulent period. It applies equally to the pace of technological change, especially with AI. Advances are arriving so rapidly that smart people are predicting business models and entire industries may be reshaped in the next 18 to 24 months. In this environment, CEOs must be attuned not just to what is changing, but to how fast it's changing—and whether now is the time to watch, pivot, or accelerate.

Organizations have a critical role to play in helping leaders develop these judgment skills. This is a moment for vigorous, open debate. One of the enduring strengths of Harvard Business School's case method is how it forces people to look at the same facts and come to different conclusions. The act of listening to others' reasoning—even, or especially, when they see things differently—sharpens your own judgment.

The goal isn't always consensus. Often, the best insight comes from a contrarian or outlier perspective. That's why companies must create a culture where rigorous, honest, open-minded dialogue is not just tolerated but actively encouraged. Psychological safety—the ability to speak freely without fear of retribution—is not a luxury; it's a necessity in today's fast-moving world.

This is what we try to cultivate in a great case classroom, and what organizations must learn to embed in their own cultures: a space where

leaders are constantly testing, refining, and improving their sense of proportion—together.

Gary Burnison: Focus on the Erstwhile “Nice-to-Have” Skills

So many factors are weighing heavily on CEOs today: shifting trade lanes, inflation and interest rates, the uncertainty swirling around AI, just to name a few. No wonder that, when talking with senior executives at global organizations, the two words I hear most often are *perpetual uncertainty*.

Although the CEO role today is more complex than ever, with some executives giving a second thought to demands of the job, the position still remains both competitive and coveted, with plenty of aspiring leaders eager to take on the challenges. Their success will be determined largely by developing skill sets and adapting their mindset to meet today’s moments.

Based on more than 108 million assessments of professionals conducted by our firm over the past five decades, we know how leaders are wired—from their traits to their competencies to their drivers. Today, three key traits stand out above the rest: *agility*, *resilience*, and *integrative thinking*. Once seen as “nice to have,” these traits are now mission critical.

Agility: If only things worked like an Excel spreadsheet—on time, on budget, and displayed with complete clarity. But that’s not realistic. Leading in this environment means anticipating what lies ahead—by accurately perceiving the reality of today. Then it’s all about course-correcting in real time—navigating ambiguity with agility. While it seems to contradict a leader’s every instinct, agility, at its core, is being willing to act without knowing every possible outcome. That takes big-

picture thinking, calculated risk-taking, and embracing the unknowns of today's world.

Resilience: Through every challenge and circumstance—the good, the bad, and everything in between—aspiring CEOs need to show their resilience. One way this happens, surprisingly perhaps, is with failure. After all, it's not the moment of failure that counts; it's what leaders will do after that. Resilience is all about the response—not retreating into isolation. That means staying visible and communicative, modeling composure and confidence, and empowering others—all of which generate momentum to move forward.

Integrative thinking: While critical thinking is essential, far more important for aspiring CEOs is integrative thinking. It's a way of processing ideas that can open more possibilities. Integrative thinking has helped guide the best of leaders through crises. It's a little like playing 3D chess—and, to be honest, it doesn't come naturally to most people.

For leaders who prioritize this skill, integrative thinking will help them lead their organizations in an increasingly complex world. Think of it as tapping Google Earth—and give yourself the broadest perspective. For example, you will need ask yourself thought-provoking questions that widen your lens. How do the decisions I'm making affect other parts of the company? Do they align with the overall strategy? What are the long-term, broad implications of taking an action?

Integrative thinking is all about considering multiple and even opposing ideas and perspectives and synthesizing them into a new solution. Today calls for shifting our lens from 30,000 feet to ground level—and having awareness of all the airspace in between.

Integrative Thinking – Explained Simply
Integrative thinking means seeing connections between opposing ideas and combining them to create a better solution instead of choosing just one side.

A critical thinker analyses and judges, but an integrative thinker connects and reimagines.

It's like playing 3D chess — you don't think in straight lines, but across different layers and perspectives. When a problem looks like "either/or," an integrative thinker asks, "Can I combine the best of both?"

Example:

Suppose a company must choose between low cost and high quality. A critical thinker picks one — maybe "low cost."

An integrative thinker asks,

"How can we innovate so we deliver high quality at a lower cost?" That leads to new business models like IKEA or budget airlines.

More than any specific skill, trait, or behavior, what leadership really requires is self-awareness. No wonder Socrates called self-knowledge “the beginning of wisdom.” Before focusing outward, it’s important to first look inward. That’s how the next generation of leaders will move onward—and even into the CEO role.

Research from Korn Ferry shows that when it comes to self-awareness—and being accountable for how we are perceived—many leaders struggle, and a whopping 79% of leaders fail to see their own skills and deficiencies clearly. Not only that, but people who greatly overstate their abilities are about six times more likely to derail than those who are self-aware. Organizations will need to develop the CEOs of tomorrow by helping them see themselves more clearly through ongoing assessment, feedback, and reflection.

More Resources

[6 Essential Leadership Skills — and How to Develop Them](#)

[When the Best Leadership Skill Is Just Being Present](#)

[Empathy Is a Non-Negotiable Leadership Skill. Here’s How to Practice It.](#)

[Tom Brady on the Art of Leading Teammates](#)

[To Build Resilience, CEOs Need to Become Supply-Chain Experts](#)

[Great Leaders Make People Feel Noticed](#)

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